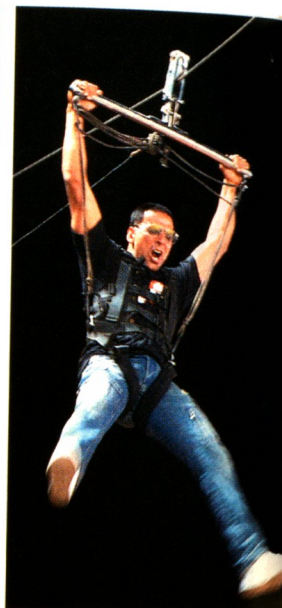


PURSHOTTAM DIWAKAR



MAIL TODAY



MID-DAY



CELEB CIRCUS:
Kareena Kapoor,
Anil Kapoor with
the Ambanis

PLAYING THE GAME

IPL GRAND OPENING

Match	TVR	Viewer reach
KKR vs RC, B'lore	8.21	12.5 m
RR vs DD, Delhi	5.58	10.4 m
CSK vs KP, Mohali	4.97	8.6 m
Opening ceremony	2.90	4.6 m

*KKR: Kolkata Knight Riders, RC: Royal Challengers
DD: Delhi Daredevils, RR: Rajasthan Royals,
CSK: Chennai Super Kings, KP: Kings XI Punjab

or witnessing the latest Indian household star Brendon McCullum heave six after six into ink-blue skies, the IPL found a way to keep millions of eyeballs fixed on it during the first weekend.

Early ratings (see box) swept aside reality shows and weepy soaps and dealt a clean KO to the IPL's nearest rival, the Zee-backed Indian Cricket League (ICL). On Cricinfo, the world's biggest cricket website, IPL pages generated 4.5 million views, the highest-ever recorded by the site for any event, other than the India vs Pakistan World T20 final.

The ratings have declared the IPL to be a roaring success and most associated with it cannot stop gloating. IPL Governing Council member Ravi Shastri abandoned all fear of overstatement as

he wrote, "We are witnessing probably the biggest moment of the game yet... Lalit Modi is the Moses of the game who has shown the path to blazing success." On finals night in Mumbai, along with other closing ceremonies, Modi presumably will also be parting the Arabian Sea.

In reality, cricket's "spindustry" would not have allowed the IPL to fail. Too many had too much riding on it—franchise owners, BCCI officials, television executives, all the way down to marketing men in newspapers, magazines and websites which sold advertising around the IPL, even while the threat of a media boycott loomed.

The IPL's entire structure rests on the TV ratings advertising generator for which it is critical that on TV it contin-

ues to look like it has host cities agog—for the next five weeks. IPL CEO Sundar Raman says the challenge now is to "keep the momentum going, get people coming back to the ground for seven matches in a row, to put bums on seats".

Calculating the real ticket-buying derrieres is turning out to be espionage, not arithmetic, a secret told only through the hiss of teeth. In Delhi, it was whispered that Bangalore had not sold any ticket; in Jaipur the following day the discussion was around the number of complimentary in Delhi. Victory in the first match and the prospect of sighting Shah Rukh sent sales soaring in Kolkata, clubs receiving only 10 complimentary each—or so it was said.

A senior franchise manager admit-